

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Codes of Ethics and Codes of Conduct - Complete Topic Package

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Codes of Ethics and Codes of Conduct

TEN-SESSION CORE PATH • PRACTICE • OPTIONAL ADVANCED • REGISTER NOTES

- | | |
|--|---|
| 1 Why public institutions need both ethical aspiration and conduct control | 2 Code of Ethics versus Code of Conduct: the controlling distinction |
| 3 Translating public-service values into rules, procedures and reasons | 4 Civil-service conduct rules: neutrality, information, speech and outside interests |
| 5 Conflict controls: gifts, hospitality, assets, relatives and recusal | 6 Ministers and legislators: political responsibility, interests and House discipline |
| 7 Institutional ownership: advice, training, monitoring, reporting and periodic review | 8 Enforcement with fairness: sanctions, proof, proportionality and due process |
| 9 Why codes fail: loopholes, ritual compliance and the ethical-competence response | 10 PYQ synthesis, current official anchors and complete answer architecture |

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Codes of Ethics and Codes of Conduct - Complete Topic Package

Subject: Ethics **Section:** Subject-wide Syllabus **Generation:** learner-v2:g1 **Ownership:** GS-IV Ethics topic; recent official-paper questions retain their exact year, paper and source note. **Source policy:** complete Basic owner first; solved practice before optional Advanced depth; consolidated register notes last.

CURRENT-AFFAIRS ANCHOR

Live official conduct-rule and parliamentary-ethics architecture, verified 29 August 2026

- **FACT:** Fact: The Department of Personnel and Training currently hosts an official page titled Central Civil Services (Conduct) Rules, 1964 (Updated).
- **FACT:** Fact: The official CCS framework includes Rule 3 general conduct and separate rules concerning political activity, media or public criticism, official information, gifts, private trade or employment and property.
- **FACT:** Fact: The live Rajya Sabha Committee on Ethics rules state that the Committee oversees members' moral and ethical conduct and prepares a Code of Conduct and proposed amendments.
- **FACT:** Fact: Those rules provide for a Register of Members' Interests and permit written complaints by any person concerning alleged unethical behaviour, breach of the Code or incorrect interest information.
- **FACT:** Fact: Where breach is found, the Committee may recommend censure, reprimand, suspension for a specified period or another appropriate sanction; the report then proceeds through Council consideration.

ANALYSIS: Inference / administrative link: The two official sources show the difference between civil-service discipline and legislative self-regulation while illustrating the shared control sequence: state standards, declare interests, create a complaint route, investigate through the competent institution and attach consequence through the legally appropriate forum.

ANALYSIS: Limit: Current official hosting of conduct rules and parliamentary ethics procedure does not establish that the Second ARC's proposed comprehensive civil-service Code of Ethics has been implemented. The official 2024 GS-IV Q5(a) expressly framed a Code of Ethics as not yet put in place. The direct 2025 code question is Q6(a); 2025 Q5(a) concerns devotion to duty. Mutable gift or property thresholds must be checked against the latest applicable notification.

Official source links:

- <https://dopt.gov.in/acts/central-civil-services-conduct-rules-1964-updated-0>
- https://cms.rajyasabha.nic.in/UploadedFiles/CommitteeSection/CommitteeRules/1626363812501.54_CommitteeOnEthics.pdf

Source caution: The corrected Topic 16 Basic and Advanced owners control the conceptual spine. A Code of Ethics is primarily aspirational and principle-based; a Code of Conduct specifies role behaviour, procedures and consequences. Do not say that an aspirational ethics code is legally self-executing. A value can become enforceable only when incorporated by competent law, service rule, House procedure, contract or other valid instrument and applied through due process. India does have enforceable conduct frameworks for civil servants and conduct or ethics arrangements for Ministers and legislators; the gap is not an absence of all codes. The Second ARC recommended public-service values applicable across governments and comprehensive treatment of conflicts in both ethics and conduct codes, but the recommended comprehensive civil-service Code of Ethics remains unimplemented as a distinct national framework. The official direct code-gap PYQ is 2024 GS-IV Q5(a). In the local official 2025 paper, Q5(a) concerns devotion to duty and is included only as an internalisation route; the direct organisational code question is 2025 Q6(a). CCS Rule numbers are cited at a stable subject level: Rule 3 general conduct, Rule 5 politics, Rules 8-9 media and criticism, Rule 11 official information, Rule 13 gifts, Rule 15 private trade or employment and Rule 18 property. Exact monetary thresholds, forms, covered groups and amendment dates are mutable and must be verified in the current consolidated text or notification. Confidentiality does not license concealment of illegality, and whistleblowing does not authorise indiscriminate public disclosure. Conflict of interest is a risk condition requiring management, not automatic proof of corruption. Asset declarations are evidence inputs, not conclusive proof. Ethics Committee recommendations must not be described as identical to final House action. Ministerial political responsibility, service discipline, House privilege and criminal liability remain distinct accountability routes. Topic 16

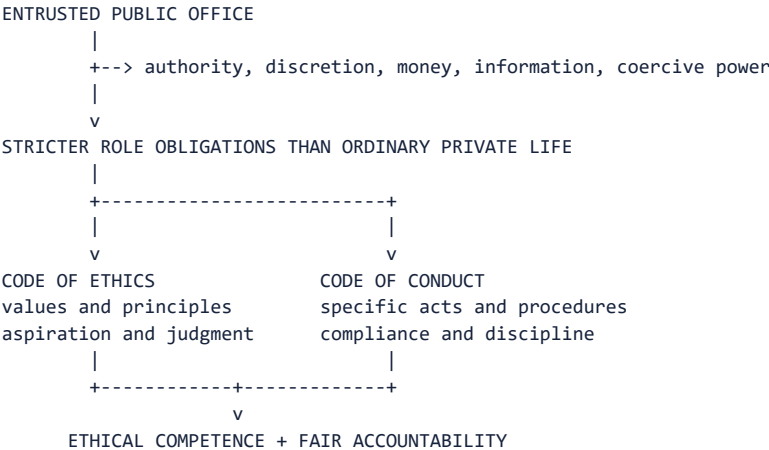
teaches design and short applications; the full case-study method remains owned by Topic 22. Official PYQ PDFs control question text, while routing ledgers only allocate ownership.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

SESSION 1 - Why public institutions need both ethical aspiration and conduct control

Subject: Ethics | **GS Paper:** GS-IV | **Topic owner:** 16 **Scope:** aspirational Codes of Ethics, enforceable Codes of Conduct, values-to-rules translation, civil servants, Ministers, legislators, conflicts, implementation and fair enforcement. Full case-study method remains Topic 22-owned. **Core sources:** Second ARC, Fourth Report, *Ethics in Governance* (2007), Chapter 2; Central Civil Services (Conduct) Rules, 1964 (official DoPT updated page); official Rajya Sabha Committee on Ethics rules; official GS-IV papers for 2018, 2019, 2022, 2023, 2024 and 2025. **FACT:** = source-grounded fact | **ANALYSIS:** = analysis/inference | **CURRENT:** = current official anchor.

1. Why public institutions need both kinds of code



FACT: The Second ARC explains that the public-action/private-interest interface creates a need for both a Code of Ethics and a Code of Conduct. Public servants exercise powers and use resources held for public purposes; conduct acceptable in ordinary private life may therefore require disclosure, restriction or abstention in office.

ANALYSIS: Exam thesis: an ethics system needs both a **compass** and **guardrails**. Values without operational rules may become rhetoric; rules without values encourage literal, evasive or fear-driven compliance.

SESSION 2 - Code of Ethics versus Code of Conduct: the controlling distinction

2. The controlling distinction

Dimension	Code of Ethics	Code of Conduct
FACT: Core form	Broad guiding values and principles	Specific expected or prohibited behaviour
Main question	What should a worthy public servant or institution aspire to be?	Who must do or avoid what, in which circumstances and through what procedure?
Primary field	Intention, disposition, judgment and institutional character	Observable acts, omissions, reporting and compliance
Typical content	Integrity, selflessness, impartiality, empathy, openness, accountability, service	Gifts, political activity, official information, outside employment, property returns, conflict disclosure
Enforcement	Not automatically sanctionable merely because it is aspirational	Enforceable when issued under competent legal or institutional authority
Main strength	Guides novel dilemmas and the spirit of public service	Gives notice, consistency, records and a basis for discipline
Main weakness	Can become symbolic or vague	Can become mechanical, loophole-driven or minimum compliance

FACT: ARC paragraph 2.2.6 describes a Code of Ethics as covering broad guiding principles of good behaviour and governance. A more specific Code of Conduct should state acceptable and unacceptable behaviour and action precisely and unambiguously.

The most important qualification

ANALYSIS: An aspirational Code of Ethics is **not legally self-executing**. A declaration that officers should show integrity or empathy does not, by itself, define an offence, create dismissal power or displace disciplinary procedure.

Enforceability requires:

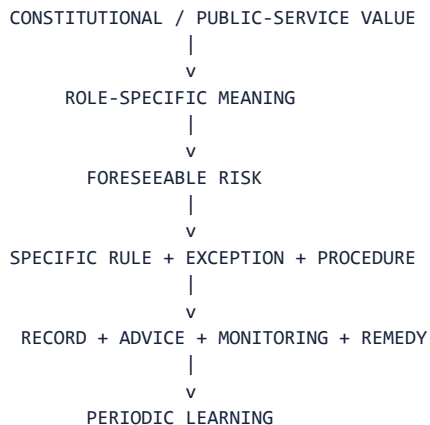
1. a competent legal or institutional source;
2. a sufficiently clear applicable standard;
3. identified authority and procedure;
4. evidence and an impartial finding;
5. proportionate consequence; and
6. review or appeal where the governing framework provides it.

ANALYSIS: Conversely, do not write that ethical values can **never** be enforceable. When a competent rule validly incorporates integrity, neutrality or conflict duties, breach may become disciplinary misconduct. The accurate distinction is between **aspirational language by itself** and a **standard validly incorporated into an enforceable regime**.

UPSC trap: "Code of Ethics has no sanction; Code of Conduct has sanction" is a useful first contrast but an unsafe absolute. Add the incorporation-and-due-process qualification.

SESSION 3 - Translating public-service values into rules, procedures and reasons

3. Translating values into rules



Translation matrix

Semantic table split - Value

- **Value:** Integrity
- **Risk:** benefit or obligation distorts duty
- **Conduct expression:** refuse/report gifts; disclose interests
- **Operational mechanism:** gift register, approval, audit
- **Value:** Impartiality
- **Risk:** relative or associate gains favour
- **Conduct expression:** declare and manage conflict
- **Operational mechanism:** recusal, reassignment, reasons
- **Value:** Political neutrality
- **Risk:** office becomes party instrument
- **Conduct expression:** restrict partisan activity and official-resource misuse
- **Operational mechanism:** role separation, written directions
- **Value:** Openness
- **Risk:** opaque discretion hides capture
- **Conduct expression:** record criteria and reasons
- **Operational mechanism:** disclosure, appeal, audit trail
- **Value:** Accountability
- **Risk:** no one owns failure
- **Conduct expression:** assign decision and supervisory responsibility
- **Operational mechanism:** inquiry, corrective order, reporting
- **Value:** Service
- **Risk:** formal process excludes vulnerable citizens
- **Conduct expression:** require courtesy, responsiveness and lawful assistance
- **Operational mechanism:** accessible channel, grievance remedy
- **Value:** Stewardship
- **Risk:** public resources used for private convenience
- **Conduct expression:** economy and public purpose
- **Operational mechanism:** procurement control, utilisation audit

ANALYSIS: Translation must preserve the **purpose** of the value. A disclosure form that is never reviewed does not institutionalise integrity. A public register that reveals unnecessary family data may violate privacy without improving conflict control.

Rule-design checklist

- define who is covered;
- define the risk and required/prohibited conduct;
- state exceptions and approval authority;
- distinguish prior permission, prior intimation and later reporting;
- provide valuation, record and time rules where relevant;
- state who advises, investigates and decides;
- specify consequences through the competent instrument;
- preserve notice, hearing, reasons and review;
- include an anti-circumvention principle; and
- review the rule when technology, work patterns or case law changes.

SESSION 4 - Civil-service conduct rules: neutrality, information, speech and outside interests

4. India's architecture: what exists and what remains missing

What exists

FACT: **Civil servants:** the Central Civil Services (Conduct) Rules, 1964 and the All India Services (Conduct) Rules, 1968 provide enforceable service-conduct frameworks for their respective populations. Breaches are handled through the applicable disciplinary architecture.

FACT: **Ministers:** India has a ministerial Code of Conduct. The Second ARC examined it and recommended an additional ethical framework, monitoring and public reporting.

FACT: **Legislators:** the Houses have ethics and conduct arrangements. The official Rajya Sabha rules empower its Committee on Ethics to oversee moral and ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, deal with interests and complaints, and recommend sanctions.

What must not be falsely claimed

ANALYSIS: India does **not** lack all conduct control. The precise gap is that the Second ARC-recommended comprehensive, coherent civil-service **Code of Ethics/public-service-values framework** has not been implemented as a distinct national layer above the existing conduct rules.

FACT: The official 2024 GS-IV Q5(a) itself states that a Code of Conduct is already in operation whereas a Code of Ethics is not yet put in place.

Factual correction: the direct “not yet put in place” question is **2024 GS-IV Q5(a)**. In the local official **2025** paper, Q5(a) concerns devotion to duty; the direct organisational code question is **2025 GS-IV Q6(a)**.

5. Civil-service conduct rules: the safe conceptual map

CCS rule families

Rule family	Safe exam-level use
FACT: Rule 3	general conduct: integrity, devotion to duty, becoming conduct, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest
FACT: Rule 5	taking part in politics and elections
FACT: Rule 8	connection with press or other media
FACT: Rule 9	criticism of Government
FACT: Rule 11	communication of official information
FACT: Rule 13	gifts
FACT: Rule 15	private trade or employment
FACT: Rule 18	movable, immovable and valuable property

ANALYSIS: Exact thresholds, forms, classes of employees and amendment positions must be checked in the current consolidated rule or notification. Do not invent a rupee amount from memory.

Rule 3 as the bridge between ethics and conduct

FACT: Rule 3 contains general obligations such as absolute integrity and devotion to duty. Its expanded standards include high ethical standards, political neutrality, merit, fairness, impartiality, accountability, transparency, responsiveness, courtesy, public-interest decision, efficient use of resources, conflict declaration and professionalism.

ANALYSIS: This does not eliminate the conceptual need for a Code of Ethics. Rule 3 makes several values enforceable as conduct duties; a full ethics code would explain the aspirational vision, decision principles, examples and learning culture beyond a disciplinary rulebook.

Oral directions

FACT: The Rule 3 supervisory framework expects official directions to be in writing where practicable and requires a subordinate receiving an oral direction to seek written confirmation.

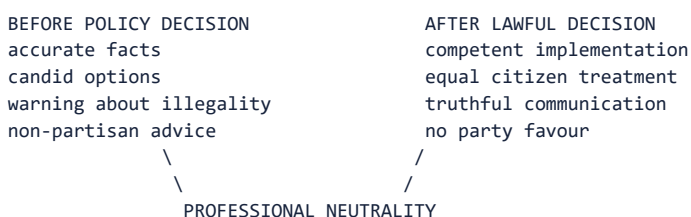
Correct response sequence:

1. clarify the direction and relevant facts;
2. respectfully state legal or ethical concern;
3. seek written confirmation where applicable;
4. do not alter or destroy records;
5. use the authorised superior, vigilance, legal or review channel;
6. refuse an unlawful act rather than hide behind “orders”; and
7. preserve service delivery during genuine emergencies.

ANALYSIS: The safeguard does not mean every oral operational instruction is invalid. Urgency may require oral coordination; material directions should be regularised and recorded.

6. Political neutrality, public statements and official information

Political neutrality



ANALYSIS: Neutrality is not moral emptiness. A civil servant remains bound by the Constitution, law, evidence and public interest. Nor is it disloyalty to give unwelcome professional advice.

Public statements

FACT: Conduct rules concerning media connection and criticism of Government protect discipline, confidential information and the perceived neutrality of service.

ANALYSIS: Apply them with lawful speech rights, authorised communication, academic roles, whistleblowing channels and proportionality. An authorised spokesperson giving verified information is not equivalent to a serving officer using departmental data for partisan attack.

Official information

FACT: Unauthorised sharing of official information can breach conduct obligations and harm privacy, security, procurement or deliberation.

ANALYSIS: Confidentiality is not a licence to conceal illegality. The ethical route is lawful disclosure: RTI processes, competent audit, vigilance, court, legislative or protected-reporting channels as applicable. Whistleblowing also does not authorise indiscriminate publication of an entire file.

SESSION 5 - Conflict controls: gifts, hospitality, assets, relatives and recusal

7. Conflict of interest

Definition and types

Type	Meaning	India-centric example
Actual	private interest presently intersects official decision	officer evaluates spouse-controlled bidder
Potential	foreseeable future intersection	regulator negotiates employment with a firm likely to enter her jurisdiction
Apparent	reasonable observer may doubt impartiality	repeated private hospitality from a regulated entity

ANALYSIS: Conflict of interest is a **risk condition**. It can exist without bribery, actual bias or a completed corrupt decision.

Management ladder

IDENTIFY
v
DISCLOSE BEFORE PARTICIPATION
v
INDEPENDENT MATERIALITY ASSESSMENT
v
RESTRICT ACCESS / RECUSE / REASSIGN / DIVEST
v
RECORD REASONS AND CONTROL
v
REVIEW OUTCOME AND RECURRING RISK

ANALYSIS: Disclosure is not always a cure. A procurement chair cannot merely announce that her spouse controls a bidder and continue to cast the deciding vote.

ANALYSIS: Recusal is also not automatic for every remote interest. A disclosed, widely diversified, immaterial holding may be managed differently after independent assessment. Proportionality avoids both capture and administrative paralysis.

8. Gifts and hospitality

Why they matter

- gratitude may distort judgment;
- hospitality can purchase privileged access;

- repeated small benefits can create dependency;
- a benefit routed through a relative can evade a literal rule;
- public appearance can damage trust even without an express bargain.

Proper control questions

1. Who offered the benefit and what official dealings exist?
2. Was it personal, official, ceremonial or widely available?
3. What is its current value under the applicable procedure?
4. Must it be refused, reported, surrendered, valued or approved?
5. Is there a pending or foreseeable decision?
6. Are connected benefits being split among relatives or intermediaries?
7. What record and review are required?

ANALYSIS: Do not quote a gift threshold unless verified against the current rule applicable to that person. Ministerial, CCS, AIS, foreign-gift and institutional repository rules are not one universal regime.

UPSC trap

WRONG: "Below the threshold means ethical." FACT: A threshold may determine reporting or permission; it cannot legitimise a deliberately split benefit or a benefit that creates an unmanaged conflict.

9. Assets, outside employment and post-employment

Asset and property declarations

FACT: Conduct frameworks use property returns and transaction reporting as preventive and investigative inputs.

ANALYSIS: Regimes differ in population, timing, content, authority, confidentiality and public access. Do not merge:

- service-rule returns;
- parliamentary declarations;
- election-law declarations; and
- anti-corruption-law declarations.

ANALYSIS: An asset anomaly is not conclusive proof of illicit enrichment. The proper route is comparison, valuation, explanation, evidence, reasoned finding and applicable proceeding.

Private trade or employment

Risks include:

- divided loyalty;
- use of official time or resources;
- advantage from confidential information;
- preferential regulation;
- pressure on subordinates;
- future-employer favour.

Possible controls include prior permission, disclosure, restriction, recusal, cooling-off and case-specific prohibition.

ANALYSIS: A blanket lifetime ban would often be disproportionate; restriction should match the role, information and foreseeable risk.

SESSION 6 - Ministers and legislators: political responsibility, interests and House discipline

10. Ministers

Ethical content

FACT: The ARC's ministerial framework includes:

- highest ethical standards;
- collective responsibility;
- accountability to Parliament for departmental policies, decisions and actions;
- avoidance of actual or apparent conflict;
- separation of ministerial and constituency roles where relevant;
- no use of government resources for party or political purposes;
- responsibility rather than blaming officials;
- protection of civil-service political impartiality;
- compliance with parliamentary requirements;
- no misuse of official position or information; and
- truthful, accountable public leadership.

Institutional design

FACT: The ARC recommended:

- a Code of Ethics in addition to the existing Code of Conduct;
- monitoring units in the Prime Minister's and Chief Ministers' Offices;
- a public complaint route;
- responsibility of the PM/CM for observance, including coalition Ministers;
- annual reporting to the legislature on violations and action; and
- public availability of the codes and report.

ANALYSIS: Ministerial consequence is often political. Resignation or removal may follow loss of confidence even without criminal conviction. This must not be confused with civil-service discipline or court punishment.

11. Legislators

Rajya Sabha official structure

CURRENT: The official Committee on Ethics rules, live-verified on 29 August 2026, state that the Committee:

- oversees the moral and ethical conduct of members;
- prepares a Code of Conduct and proposes amendments;
- maintains an interests architecture;
- may receive written complaints from any person;
- may act on alleged unethical behaviour, Code breach or incorrect interest information; and
- may recommend censure, reprimand, suspension for a specified period or another appropriate sanction.

ANALYSIS: The Committee **recommends** and reports; the House/Council process that follows must not be collapsed into the Committee's inquiry.

Legislator ethics principles

- private interest must yield to public trust;
- payment or benefit for a vote, question, bill or parliamentary act is impermissible;
- interests relevant to proceedings should be declared;
- conduct should preserve the dignity and credibility of the House;

- allegation, inquiry, recommendation and House decision are separate stages.

SESSION 7 - Institutional ownership: advice, training, monitoring, reporting and periodic review

12. Institutional ownership and advice

A code needs an identifiable owner. Otherwise:

- employees receive inconsistent interpretations;
- no one maintains forms or examples;
- disclosure data is collected but unused;
- advice is unsafe or unavailable;
- complaints are misrouted;
- leaders escape reporting; and
- obsolete rules survive.

Ethics-office functions

Preventive	Monitoring	Corrective/learning
guidance and FAQs	disclosure timeliness	complaint routing
confidential prospective advice	recusal quality	trend analysis
scenario training	risk and climate surveys	revision proposals
leadership support	audit anomalies	annual aggregate report

ANALYSIS: Advice and investigation may require separation. An adviser who encouraged candid consultation should not automatically become witness, prosecutor and adjudicator without clear safeguards.

13. Training and ethical competence

What competence includes

1. noticing an ethical signal;
2. identifying the applicable law, rule and value;
3. recognising conflicts and cognitive bias;
4. mapping affected stakeholders;
5. generating lawful alternatives;
6. seeking advice early;
7. giving contemporaneous reasons;
8. escalating safely;
9. accepting review; and
10. learning from error and near misses.

ANALYSIS: Memorising gift limits is not ethical competence. An officer must recognise disguised hospitality, benefits routed through relatives and situations in which disclosure alone is insufficient.

Training methods

- induction plus periodic refreshers;
- dilemma-based Indian administrative scenarios;
- role-play between Minister, Secretary, vendor and citizen;
- anonymous near-miss discussion;
- short written-reasons exercises;
- leadership modelling;

- protected questions without career penalty; and
- evaluation based on judgment, not attendance alone.

14. Monitoring and review

Balanced indicators

Leading indicators	Lagging indicators
advice requests	substantiated complaints
timely disclosures	disciplinary findings
quality of recusal reasons	repeated audit loss
staff confidence in speaking up	retaliation findings
near-miss reporting	judicial/tribunal reversals
training judgment performance	confirmed information breaches

ANALYSIS: Fewer complaints do not necessarily mean better ethics. Reporting may have become dangerous or inaccessible. Raw sanction numbers can also reward over-punishment.

Periodic review

Use:

- recurring advisory questions;
- complaint and audit patterns;
- court and tribunal findings;
- technological change;
- remote and platform work;
- staff and citizen experience;
- implementation cost; and
- comparison across units.

Revisions should operate prospectively, with consultation and transition guidance. Retroactive discipline under a newly clarified rule violates fairness.

SESSION 8 - Enforcement with fairness: sanctions, proof, proportionality and due process

15. Sanctions and due process

VALID APPLICABLE RULE
 v
 EVIDENCE PRESERVED LAWFULLY
 v
 NOTICE + RELEVANT MATERIAL
 v
 IMPARTIAL INQUIRY + RESPONSE
 v
 REASONED FINDING
 v
 PROPORTIONATE CONSEQUENCE
 v
 REVIEW / APPEAL / REMEDY

Proportionality factors

- gravity and public harm;
- intention or recklessness;
- value of benefit;

- seniority and abuse of influence;
- concealment or obstruction;
- repetition;
- cooperation and correction;
- effect on vulnerable persons;
- consistency with comparable cases.

ANALYSIS: Due process is not softness. It makes consequences legitimate and resilient. Equally, a good reputation or senior office cannot erase supported misconduct.

SESSION 9 - Why codes fail: loopholes, ritual compliance and the ethical-competence response

16. Loopholes and ritual compliance

Loophole	Purpose-sensitive response
split gifts below a trigger	aggregate connected benefits
benefit routed through spouse/friend	examine connected persons and beneficial ownership
private messaging for official directions	authorised record requirement and retention control
declaration after decision	transaction-specific prior disclosure
"I did not ask" defence	test knowledge, wilful blindness and circumstances
technically complete but misleading form	verify substance, not boxes alone
ethics pledge without safe reporting	confidential advice and anti-retaliation

ANALYSIS: General clauses must not become vague punishment devices. Anti-circumvention findings still require a clear rule, evidence, reasons and fair hearing.

SESSION 10 - PYQ synthesis, current official anchors and complete answer architecture

17. Current official anchors

CURRENT: DoPT

FACT: The Department of Personnel and Training currently hosts an official page titled **Central Civil Services (Conduct) Rules, 1964 (Updated)**:

<https://dopt.gov.in/acts/central-civil-services-conduct-rules-1964-updated-0>

Use: proves a live official conduct-rule framework. Limit: the hosted consolidated material and individual amendments must be checked before quoting mutable thresholds or claiming a final amendment cut-off.

CURRENT: Rajya Sabha

FACT: Official Committee on Ethics rules:

https://cms.rajyasabha.nic.in/UploadedFiles/CommitteeSection/CommitteeRules/1626363812501.54_CommitteeOnEthics.pdf

Use: proves a live institutional architecture of code preparation, interests, complaint, committee inquiry and recommended sanction. Limit: it does not prove implementation of the ARC's proposed comprehensive civil-service Code of Ethics or an independent Ethics Commissioner for every institution.

18. Official PYQ routes

Year	Route	Topic demand
FACT: 2018	Q1(b)	distinguish Code of Ethics and Code of Conduct with examples
FACT: 2018	Q2(a)	public-interest principles and procedures
FACT: 2018	Q3(a)	actual and potential conflicts of interest
FACT: 2018	Q4(b)	limits of “not expressly prohibited” reasoning
FACT: 2019	concluding Section B question	threats, ethical competence and integrity-promoting processes
FACT: 2022	Q2(a)	purposive versus negative interpretation of common rules
FACT: 2023	Q5(a)	conscience compared with laws, rules and regulations
FACT: 2024	Q5(a)	direct model Code of Ethics; conduct exists, ethics code not put in place
FACT: 2025	Q5(a)	devotion to duty, responsibility and fulfilment - internalisation route
FACT: 2025	Q6(a)	value-based and compliance-based workplace culture

Numbering caution

The official 2025 local PDF verifies:

- **Q5(a):** “One who is devoted to one’s duty attains highest perfection in life...”;
- **Q6(a):** “It is said that for an ethical work culture, there must be code of ethics...”.

Do not relabel the direct 2024 code-gap question as 2025.

19. Answer architecture

10 marks

Definition/distinction

+

2-3 operational dimensions

+

Indian rule/institution/example

+

one qualification

+

balanced conclusion

15 marks

1. define the code and diagnose the gap;
2. state values;
3. translate them into risk-specific rules;
4. add advice, training and monitoring;
5. add fair enforcement;
6. distinguish aspiration from legal self-execution; and
7. conclude with prevention plus accountability.

20 marks

Use a role-wise structure:

1. civil servants;
2. Ministers;
3. legislators;

4. shared ethical minimum;
5. separate accountability forums;
6. institutional ownership;
7. loophole and competence response;
8. proportionality and due process.

Answer-grabbing line: A mature ethics regime does not choose between values and compliance; it makes values usable before misconduct and compliance legitimate after it.

20. Consolidated rapid-revision notes

- FACT: Ethics code = broad values, aspiration and judgment.
- FACT: Conduct code = specific role behaviour, procedure and enforceable consequence where validly issued.
- ANALYSIS: Aspirational ethics language is not legally self-executing.
- FACT: India has civil-service conduct rules, a Ministers' Code of Conduct and legislative ethics arrangements.
- ANALYSIS: The comprehensive ARC-recommended civil-service Code of Ethics remains unimplemented as a distinct national framework.
- FACT: Direct code-gap PYQ = **2024 Q5(a)**.
- FACT: 2025 Q5(a) = devotion to duty; 2025 Q6(a) = organisational Code of Ethics and work culture.
- FACT: CCS anchors: Rule 3, Rule 5, Rules 8-9, Rule 11, Rule 13, Rule 15, Rule 18.
- ANALYSIS: Verify current thresholds and forms; do not guess.
- Conflict is a risk condition, not proof of corruption.
- Disclosure may require recusal, reassignment or divestment.
- Gifts test obligation and appearance, not value alone.
- Asset returns are evidence inputs with privacy and due-process limits.
- Neutrality = candid non-partisan advice plus lawful implementation.
- Confidentiality requires authorised handling, not concealment of illegality.
- A code needs ownership, advice, training, monitoring, enforcement and review.
- Sanction route = valid rule -> evidence -> hearing -> reasons -> proportionality -> review.
- Anti-loophole control must remain clear and non-retroactive.
- Ethical competence joins character, rule knowledge and practical judgment.
- Topic 22 owns the full case-study method.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1

A department publishes selflessness, impartiality and service as ideals but states no gift, disclosure or recusal rule. Which kind of code has it mainly created? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable.
- B. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process.
- C. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity.
- D. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision.

Answer: A

Explanation: Ethics codes guide aspiration; conduct codes specify behaviour is the controlling principle. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 2

A service rule fixes when an interest must be declared and what disciplinary process may follow concealment. Which kind of code is operating? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity.
- B. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable.
- C. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision.
- D. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process.

Answer: B

Explanation: Ethics codes guide aspiration; conduct codes specify behaviour is the controlling principle. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 3

An ethics charter says officials should show empathy. A manager treats the sentence alone as automatic authority to dismiss an employee. Which legal-ethical error arises? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable.
- B. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity.
- C. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process.
- D. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision.

Answer: C

Explanation: An aspirational code is not legally self-executing is the controlling principle. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 4

A value is incorporated into a notified conduct rule with a defined breach procedure. What changed its institutional status? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity.
- B. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision.
- C. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable.
- D. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process.

Answer: D

Explanation: An aspirational code is not legally self-executing is the controlling principle. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 5

A licensing officer argues that a private dinner with a bidder is acceptable because an ordinary citizen may dine with anyone. Which role-based point defeats the argument? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity.
- B. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable.
- C. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process.
- D. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision.

Answer: A

Explanation: Public servants face stricter role obligations is the controlling principle. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 6

Why may a lawful private activity still require restriction or disclosure when an official's public duties are materially connected to it? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process.
- B. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity.
- C. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision.
- D. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable.

Answer: B

Explanation: Public servants face stricter role obligations is the controlling principle. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 7

A code praises integrity but gives procurement staff no conflict form or recusal route. At which translation stage has the system failed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable.
- B. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process.
- C. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision.
- D. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Values require a translation chain** is the controlling principle. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 8

An organisation maps favouritism risk into disclosure, reassignment and audit steps. Which values-to-rules method is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process.
- B. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity.
- C. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable.
- D. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Values require a translation chain** is the controlling principle. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 9

A rule bans 'improper association' without definition, examples, advice or reviewing authority. Which rule-of-law defect is most evident? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ.
- B. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest.
- C. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice.
- D. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Rule design must be clear without becoming mechanical** is the controlling principle. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 10

A gift rule defines ordinary exceptions, reporting, valuation and approval while requiring reasons for borderline cases. Which design balance is achieved? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice.
- B. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ.
- C. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders.
- D. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Rule design must be clear without becoming mechanical** is the controlling principle. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 11

An official claims neutrality is merely optional professional advice. Which existing conduct-rule architecture contradicts the claim? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ.
- B. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice.
- C. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest.
- D. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders.

Answer: C

Explanation: Rule 3 supplies a general civil-service conduct floor is the controlling principle. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 12

A decision is formally efficient but openly advances the officer's private interest. Which Rule 3 public-interest and conflict standard is implicated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice.
- B. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders.
- C. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ.
- D. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest.

Answer: D

Explanation: Rule 3 supplies a general civil-service conduct floor is the controlling principle. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 13

A civil servant refuses to implement a lawful policy solely because another party adopted it. Is this neutrality or partisan obstruction? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice.
- B. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ.
- C. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest.
- D. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Political neutrality differs from political indifference** is the controlling principle. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 14

An officer gives candid evidence-based advice, then faithfully implements the lawful ministerial decision. Which conception of neutrality is shown? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest.
- B. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice.
- C. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders.
- D. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Political neutrality differs from political indifference** is the controlling principle. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 15

A superior orally orders alteration of eligibility records and refuses to confirm it. What immediate conduct safeguard should the subordinate use? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ.
- B. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest.
- C. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders.
- D. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice.

Answer: C

Explanation: Written-direction safeguards protect responsibility is the controlling principle. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 16

Why is seeking written confirmation different from automatically refusing every oral instruction during an emergency? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest.
- B. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice.
- C. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ.
- D. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders.

Answer: D

Explanation: Written-direction safeguards protect responsibility is the controlling principle. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 17

An officer sends a confidential bidder's commercial data to a friend. Which conduct risk is primary? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable.
- B. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality.
- C. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict.
- D. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Official information is governed by lawful purpose** is the controlling principle. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 18

An employee reports evidence through a legally authorised vigilance channel rather than posting the entire file online. Which balanced information ethic is shown? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict.
- B. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable.
- C. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility.
- D. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Official information is governed by lawful purpose** is the controlling principle. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 19

A serving officer uses undisclosed departmental data in a partisan televised attack. Which combined concerns arise? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable.
- B. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict.
- C. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality.
- D. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Public statements require role clarity** is the controlling principle. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 20

An authorised spokesperson gives verified information within the approved mandate. Why is this not equivalent to partisan misuse of office? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict.
- B. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility.
- C. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable.
- D. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Public statements require role clarity** is the controlling principle. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 21

An officer's sibling owns a bidding firm, although the officer has not yet favoured it. What ethical condition already exists? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict.
- B. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable.
- C. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality.
- D. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Conflict of interest is a situation, not necessarily corruption** is the controlling principle. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 22

Why should an investigation distinguish an unmanaged conflict from proved corrupt decision-making? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality.
- B. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict.
- C. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility.
- D. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Conflict of interest is a situation, not necessarily corruption** is the controlling principle. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 23

A procurement chair declares that her spouse controls a bidder and then casts the deciding vote. Why is disclosure insufficient? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable.
- B. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality.
- C. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility.
- D. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict.

Answer: C

Explanation: Disclosure alone may not cure a material conflict is the controlling principle. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 24

A minor widely held mutual-fund interest is declared and independently assessed as immaterial. Why might recusal not be automatic? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality.
- B. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict.
- C. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable.
- D. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility.

Answer: D

Explanation: Disclosure alone may not cure a material conflict is the controlling principle. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 25

A regulated company offers a luxury holiday to the inspection team before renewal. Which risk remains even if no express favour is requested? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed.
- B. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure.
- C. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth.
- D. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved.

Answer: A

Explanation: Gifts and hospitality create obligation and appearance risks is the controlling principle. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 26

A ceremonial item received officially is recorded and handled under the applicable repository procedure. Which institutional principle is demonstrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth.
- B. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed.
- C. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved.
- D. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure.

Answer: B

Explanation: Gifts and hospitality create obligation and appearance risks is the controlling principle. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 27

An investigator treats one undeclared entry as conclusive proof of corruption without hearing or valuation. Which due-process error arises? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed.
- B. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth.
- C. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure.
- D. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved.

Answer: C

Explanation: Asset declarations are a risk-control instrument is the controlling principle. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 28

A competent authority compares a return with decisions, seeks explanation and follows the prescribed inquiry. Which proper use of disclosure is shown? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth.
- B. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved.
- C. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed.
- D. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure.

Answer: D

Explanation: Asset declarations are a risk-control instrument is the controlling principle. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 29

A regulator secretly advises a company whose licence she evaluates. Which conduct problem is clearest? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth.
- B. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed.
- C. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure.
- D. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Outside employment and post-employment create divided loyalty** is the controlling principle. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 30

A retired specialist accepts unrelated teaching after satisfying applicable permission requirements. Why should a blanket lifetime ban be rejected? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure.
- B. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth.
- C. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved.
- D. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Outside employment and post-employment create divided loyalty** is the controlling principle. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 31

A Minister uses departmental staff for an election campaign. Which boundary in a ministerial code is crossed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed.
- B. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure.
- C. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved.
- D. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth.

Answer: C

Explanation: Ministers combine ethical and political accountability is the controlling principle. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 32

A Minister resigns for misleading the House although no conviction exists. Which form of responsibility is operating? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure.
- B. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth.
- C. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed.
- D. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved.

Answer: D

Explanation: Ministers combine ethical and political accountability is the controlling principle. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 33

A note says the Ethics Committee itself finally suspends a Member without House consideration. Which institutional distinction is missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step.
- B. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers.
- C. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses.
- D. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Legislative ethics uses House-owned procedures** is the controlling principle. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 34

A citizen submits a written complaint alleging a member concealed a pecuniary interest. Which official ethics mechanism may examine it? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses.
- B. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step.
- C. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts.
- D. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Legislative ethics uses House-owned procedures** is the controlling principle. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 35

A department launches a code but assigns no office to answer questions or update it. Which implementation failure is predictable? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step.
- B. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses.
- C. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers.
- D. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts.

Answer: C

Explanation: Institutional ownership prevents an orphan code is the controlling principle. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 36

An ethics office publishes guidance, protects advice confidentiality and reports aggregate trends. Which ownership model is being built? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses.
- B. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts.
- C. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step.
- D. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers.

Answer: D

Explanation: Institutional ownership prevents an orphan code is the controlling principle. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 37

Employees can recite the gift rule but cannot identify disguised hospitality through a relative. Which capability is missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses.
- B. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step.
- C. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers.
- D. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts.

Answer: A

Explanation: Training must build ethical competence is the controlling principle. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 38

Scenario drills require officials to identify a conflict, choose a management option and defend it in writing. What is the training trying to build? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers.
- B. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses.
- C. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts.
- D. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step.

Answer: B

Explanation: Training must build ethical competence is the controlling principle. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 39

A unit claims success because complaints fell after it made reporting difficult. Which measurement pathology is present? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step.
- B. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers.
- C. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts.
- D. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses.

Answer: C

Explanation: Monitoring should combine leading and lagging indicators is the controlling principle. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 40

An organisation tracks anonymous climate surveys, advice demand and repeated control failures alongside proven cases. Which monitoring approach is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers.
- B. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses.
- C. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step.
- D. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts.

Answer: D

Explanation: Monitoring should combine leading and lagging indicators is the controlling principle. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 41

An employee is dismissed on an anonymous allegation without hearing or identified rule. Which enforcement values fail? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition.
- B. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter.
- C. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps.
- D. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules.

Answer: A

Explanation: Sanctions require legality, proof and proportionality is the controlling principle. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 42

A reasoned order distinguishes inadvertent late reporting from deliberate concealment. Which sanction principle is being applied? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps.
- B. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition.
- C. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules.
- D. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter.

Answer: B

Explanation: Sanctions require legality, proof and proportionality is the controlling principle. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 43

An employee candidly seeks prospective advice, which the same officer later selectively uses to punish her without safeguards. Which design problem appears? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition.
- B. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps.
- C. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter.
- D. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules.

Answer: C

Explanation: Advice and enforcement must be separated where fairness requires is the controlling principle. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 44

Separate advice and investigation teams share only authorised records under clear rules. Which balance is protected? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps.
- B. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules.
- C. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition.
- D. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter.

Answer: D

Explanation: Advice and enforcement must be separated where fairness requires is the controlling principle. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 45

A contractor gives four family members separate benefits just below a reporting trigger. Which ethical failure survives literal threshold compliance? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

A. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps.

B. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition.

C. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter.

D. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules.

Answer: A

Explanation: Loophole compliance can violate the code's purpose is the controlling principle. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 46

A code asks whether connected benefits reasonably create obligation, not only whether one item crosses a number. Which anti-loophole method is used? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

A. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter.

B. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps.

C. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules.

D. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition.

Answer: B

Explanation: Loophole compliance can violate the code's purpose is the controlling principle. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 47

A social-media rule written before digital platforms is never reviewed despite repeated uncertainty. Which governance function has failed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition.
- B. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter.
- C. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules.
- D. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps.

Answer: C

Explanation: A mature ethics system learns and revises is the controlling principle. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 48

A revised code operates prospectively after consultation and transition guidance. Which learning-and-legality balance is shown? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter.
- B. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps.
- C. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition.
- D. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules.

Answer: D

Explanation: A mature ethics system learns and revises is the controlling principle. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q1(b): Distinguish between "Code of ethics" and "Code of conduct" with suitable examples. (150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf, page 2.

Model solution

A Code of Ethics states broad values and decision principles that persons in a role should aspire to embody: selflessness, integrity, impartiality, openness, accountability and service. It guides intention and judgment when no detailed rule resolves the case. A Code of Conduct converts recurring risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences: declare a material interest, refuse or report specified gifts, protect official information, avoid partisan activity and file property returns.

Thus an ethics code asks, 'What kind of public servant and public institution should we be?' A conduct code asks, 'What must or must not be done, by whom, through which process, and with what consequence?' The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 are an enforceable conduct framework. The Second ARC recommended comprehensive public-service values and a Code of Ethics as their complement.

The distinction is not absolute: ethical values may become enforceable when validly incorporated into rules, while conduct rules still require ethical interpretation. An aspirational code is not legally self-executing; credibility comes from joining values with advice, training, monitoring and fair disciplinary machinery.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q2(a): What is meant by public interest? What are the principles and procedures to be followed by the civil servants in public interest? (150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf, page 2.

Model solution

Public interest is the legally and constitutionally defensible welfare of the community, including fair treatment of minorities and future citizens, rather than the preference of the government, official or numerical majority. It is identified through authorised purpose, evidence, rights and impartial reasoning.

A civil servant should first establish legal competence and the policy objective; identify stakeholders, especially vulnerable groups; disclose private interests and recuse where necessary; gather reliable facts; compare feasible alternatives; and test equality, necessity, proportionality, cost and long-term consequences. Consultation should be meaningful where affected knowledge matters. The officer should give contemporaneous reasons, protect lawful confidentiality, preserve records, communicate the decision and keep review and remedy open.

Codes support this process at two levels. An ethics code supplies public purpose, selflessness and empathy; conduct rules specify conflict, information and procedural obligations. Neither popular demand nor superior instruction automatically equals public interest. The defensible decision is one an impartial institution can explain to affected citizens under law.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2018 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q3(a): What is meant by conflict of interest? Illustrate with examples, the difference between the actual and potential conflicts of interest. (150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against
books\more_previous_papers\GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf, page 2.

Model solution

A conflict of interest arises when a public official's private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It is a risk condition, not automatic proof of bribery or a biased decision.

An actual conflict exists when the private interest presently intersects the decision. For example, a procurement chair evaluates a bid from a company controlled by her spouse. A potential conflict exists when a foreseeable change could create that intersection: a regulator negotiating future employment with a firm that is likely to come under his jurisdiction, even before a specific file arrives. An apparent conflict concerns reasonable public perception and also deserves management because trust depends on visible impartiality.

The proper sequence is identify, disclose, assess materiality, restrict access, recuse or reassign where necessary, divest or use another proportionate control, and record the decision. Disclosure alone is not a cure for a material conflict. At the same time, fair inquiry must distinguish an unmanaged conflict from proved corrupt conduct before imposing disciplinary or criminal consequences.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2018 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q4(b): "In doing a good thing, everything is permitted which is not prohibited expressly or by clear implication." Examine the statement with suitable examples in the context of a public servant discharging his/her duties. (150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against
books\more_previous_papers\GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf, page 3.

Model solution

The statement rightly warns against administrative paralysis: law cannot anticipate every contingency, and a public servant may need initiative to deliver relief. During a flood, an authorised officer may choose an unlisted but lawful transport arrangement when delay would endanger life, recording necessity and later review.

However, absence of an express prohibition is not unlimited permission. Public power differs from private liberty: the official also needs legal competence, authorised purpose, equality, proportionality, financial propriety and respect for rights. A collector cannot transfer public land to a favoured charity merely because no sentence expressly names that transaction. Nor may a welfare objective justify unauthorised disclosure of personal data.

A Code of Conduct supplies the legal and procedural floor; a Code of Ethics tests purpose, fairness, selflessness and foreseeable harm where wording leaves space. The correct approach is principled discretion: verify authority, compare alternatives, seek advice when time permits, record reasons, minimise rights intrusion and accept audit. Good ends do not create power, but rules should be interpreted purposively rather than mechanically.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2019 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV, Section B concluding question: In recent times, there has been an increasing concern in India to develop effective civil service ethics, codes of conduct, transparency measures, ethics and integrity systems and anti-corruption agencies. In view of this, there is a need being felt to focus on three specific areas, which are directly relevant to the problems of internalizing integrity and ethics in the civil services. These are as follows: 1. Anticipating specific threats to ethical standards and integrity in the civil services, 2. Strengthening the ethical competence of civil servants and 3. Developing administrative processes and practices which promote ethical values and integrity in civil services. Suggest institutional measures to address the above three issues. (250 words)

Source / ownership: Faithful English text verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-IV.pdf, page 7. The source PDF's extracted numbering is not reliably attached to this final bilingual block, so the source note does not invent one.

Model solution

Institutionalisation should connect foresight, competence and process. First, each department should maintain an ethics-risk register covering discretion, procurement, gifts, relatives, information, revolving doors, political pressure and digital systems. Near-miss reporting, staff surveys, complaint patterns, audit findings and stakeholder consultation can reveal threats before scandal. High-risk posts need rotation, segregation of duties and focused review.

Second, competence requires more than reading rules. Induction and recurring scenario training should teach conflict recognition, stakeholder mapping, bias detection, reasoned discretion, written-direction safeguards and safe escalation. A confidential ethics-advice office, mentoring and protected consultation allow officials to resolve uncertainty early. Leaders must model disclosure and accept review.

Third, values must enter workflow: clear conduct rules; accessible interest and gift registers; disclosure and recusal protocols; objective criteria; written reasons; tamper-evident records; citizen charters; audit; grievance remedy; and proportionate discipline after notice, hearing and reasoned decision. Aggregate annual reporting should identify recurring risks and revisions without breaching protected data.

Aspirational ethics codes are not self-enforcing, while punishment alone produces defensive compliance. The mature system combines values, advice, capable processes, credible detection, fair sanctions and periodic learning.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2022 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q2(a): The Rules and Regulations provided to all the civil servants are same, yet there is difference in the performance. Positive minded officers are able to interpret the Rules and Regulations in favour of the case and achieve success, whereas negative minded officers are unable to achieve goals by interpreting the same Rules and Regulations against the case. Discuss with illustrations. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Faithful English text, with extraction spacing normalised, verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-22-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER IV-190922.pdf, page 2.

Model solution

Rules create equality, predictability and control of arbitrary power, but language cannot eliminate judgment. Performance differs because officers vary in competence, empathy, initiative, bias, risk appetite and understanding of statutory purpose. A positive interpretation is not one that always approves a request; it finds the lawful route that best serves the authorised objective.

For example, an officer may help an elderly pensioner cure a remediable documentation defect rather than reject the claim mechanically, while still verifying eligibility. In procurement, however, 'positive attitude' cannot excuse favouring a preferred bidder or ignoring mandatory competition. The ethical code supplies service, compassion and public purpose; the conduct code supplies limits, conflicts, records and accountability.

Administrations should issue plain guidance, examples and advice channels; train officers in purposive interpretation and reasons; protect documented good-faith discretion; and retain appeal and audit. Positivity means solution-oriented legality, not personal benevolence above law. Equally, negative literalism should not convert safeguards into avoidable exclusion.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2023 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q5(a): Is conscience a more reliable guide when compared to laws, rules and regulations in the context of ethical decision-making? Discuss. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-23-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV-180923.pdf, page 4.

Model solution

Conscience can detect cruelty, unfairness or bad faith that a general rule misses. It supports moral courage when organisational practice has normalised wrongdoing. Yet conscience is shaped by upbringing, prejudice, self-interest and incomplete facts; sincere officials may reach incompatible conclusions.

Laws and conduct rules provide democratically or institutionally authorised standards, equality, notice and review. They restrain personal whim, but can be outdated, ambiguous or used mechanically. A Code of Ethics helps interpret their purpose by stating integrity, impartiality, empathy and public service. It cannot, however, silently repeal valid law or create a penalty by itself.

Reliability therefore comes from disciplined convergence: identify the valid rule; test facts and constitutional values; examine whether the apparent conflict can be resolved by lawful interpretation; seek reasoned advice; record dissent; use authorised escalation, review or whistleblowing channels; and accept correction. In urgent illegality, an official should not obey merely because a superior invokes discipline. Conscience is a warning and reflection faculty, not a private sovereign.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2024 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q5(a): The 'Code of Conduct' and 'Code of Ethics' are the sources of guidance in public administration. There is code of conduct already in operation, whereas code of ethics is not yet put in place. Suggest a suitable model for code of ethics to maintain integrity, probity and transparency in governance. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Faithful isolated subpart verified against books\mains\05 UPSC 2024 Paper-IV_Final 1.pdf, page 3. This is the direct code-gap question; it is 2024 Q5(a), not 2025 Q5(a).

Model solution

India's model should add an aspirational public-service layer above existing conduct rules, not restate or replace them. Its foundation should be constitutional fidelity, public interest, selflessness, integrity, impartiality, objectivity, empathy, openness, accountability, stewardship and courage to tender honest advice. It should explain these values through Indian administrative dilemmas involving gifts, relatives, data, vulnerable citizens, political pressure and resource use.

Implementation needs an ethics office with sufficient independence to provide confidential advice, scenario training and conflict-management guidance; accessible interest and recusal systems; leadership declarations; aggregate annual reporting; and periodic revision after audit, tribunal and complaint learning. Citizens should know the standards claimed and the complaint route.

Actual misconduct must still be handled under valid service rules and law through notice, impartial inquiry, reasons, proportionate sanction and appeal. The ethics code is not legally self-executing. The model succeeds when values shape judgment before breach, while conduct rules and due process supply enforceable accountability after breach.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2025 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q5(a): "One who is devoted to one's duty attains highest perfection in life." Analyse this statement with reference to sense of responsibility and personal fulfilment as a civil servant. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, page 3. This is the requested 2025 Q5(a) route: it concerns devotion to duty, not the direct Code-of-Ethics gap. Topic 16 uses it only for internalisation and Rule 3 linkage.

Model solution

Devotion to duty means sustained, competent and public-purpose performance despite inconvenience, not blind obedience or work without humane limits. For a civil servant, responsibility includes understanding the lawful mandate, anticipating consequences, serving citizens impartially, protecting records and correcting avoidable error. Rule 3 of the CCS conduct framework gives devotion an institutional floor; a Code of Ethics adds service, empathy, courage and stewardship as internal motivations.

Fulfilment can arise when skill and conscience align with socially valuable work: an officer who redesigns an accessible pension process sees public impact and develops professional mastery. Trust earned through reliable service also strengthens moral agency.

Yet devotion is distorted if it means obeying an unlawful oral direction, concealing harm, partisan loyalty or burnout. The officer should seek written confirmation, give candid advice and use lawful review routes. Highest professional development lies in responsible service bounded by Constitution, law, competence and care, not unquestioning compliance with a person or target.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2025 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q6(a): It is said that for an ethical work culture, there must be code of ethics in place in every organisation. To ensure value-based and compliance-based work culture, what suitable measures would you adopt in your work place? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, page 3. This is the direct 2025 organisational-code question; it is Q6(a), not Q5(a).

Model solution

I would begin with a participatively drafted Code of Ethics stating public purpose, integrity, dignity, impartiality, openness, accountability and service, illustrated by real workplace dilemmas. A complementary conduct matrix would identify gifts, conflicts, harassment, data access, outside work, use of resources and retaliation, with clear reporting and recusal procedures.

Internalisation requires induction and refresher scenarios, leadership example, team discussion of near misses, confidential advice, mentoring and recognition of ethical problem-solving rather than target achievement alone. Compliance requires accessible complaint channels, protected reporting, segregation of duties, audit trails, risk-based monitoring and timely investigation.

Enforcement should identify the valid rule, provide notice and hearing, protect evidence, give reasoned findings, impose proportionate sanctions and permit review. Aggregate annual reporting should disclose trends and corrective action without violating privacy. Staff surveys, advice requests, recusal quality and repeated control failures should inform periodic revision. Thus values guide judgment before a breach, while precise rules and fair process make accountability credible.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: An aspirational Code of Ethics is necessary but cannot be treated as a legally self-executing disciplinary code. Explain. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

A Code of Ethics articulates the kind of public service an institution seeks: constitutional fidelity, selflessness, integrity, impartiality, empathy, openness, accountability and stewardship. It is necessary because detailed rules cannot foresee every dilemma or cultivate motive, judgment and leadership. It guides an officer facing a novel use of data or pressure that no clause fully anticipates.

However, aspiration alone does not define an offence, competent authority, evidence, procedure or penalty. Treating a broad value such as 'courtesy' as automatic dismissal power would violate legality and due process. Enforceability arises only when a competent law, service rule, contract or House procedure incorporates a standard and supplies fair machinery.

The sound architecture therefore separates but connects the layers: ethics code for values, advice and reflection; conduct code for specific duties; procedures for disclosure, recusal and records; and notice, impartial inquiry, reasons, proportionate sanction and appeal for breach. Ethics prevents misconduct; lawfully made conduct rules discipline it.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 10 marks

Question: How should a civil servant reconcile political neutrality with candid advice and faithful implementation of government policy? Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Political neutrality means service to the constitutional government without party campaigning, partisan discrimination or use of office for electoral advantage. It does not mean intellectual silence or indifference to legality. Before decision, the civil servant should give the Minister accurate facts, feasible alternatives, distributional effects and candid warning where a proposal is unlawful or imprudent. Advice should be professional, recorded where material and free from personal party preference.

After a lawful decision, the officer should implement it competently regardless of which party originated it, communicate it truthfully and preserve equal treatment. If an oral direction is doubtful, written confirmation and authorised review protect responsibility. An unlawful instruction should not be implemented merely in the name of discipline.

The conduct code supplies restrictions on political activity, public statements and official information; the ethics code supplies courage, objectivity and constitutional service. Neutrality is therefore loyal implementation of lawful policy combined with fearless, evidence-based advice, not loyalty to a person or party.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 15 marks

Question: Design a conflict-of-interest system for an Indian public organisation covering gifts, hospitality, relatives, assets and outside employment. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

The system should begin with a broad definition: a private interest that could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It must distinguish actual, potential and apparent conflict from proved corruption. Covered interests should include financial holdings, relatives and close associates, gifts and hospitality, debts, outside employment, future employment and confidential information.

Operationally, officials should file role-sensitive declarations on entry, periodically and on material change. Procurement and licensing decisions need transaction-specific disclosure. A trained ethics office should assess materiality and choose proportionate management: refuse or surrender a benefit, restrict access, recuse and reassign, divest, use a blind arrangement, or obtain permission under the applicable rule. Monetary gift limits must be drawn from the current notified rule, not improvised.

Registers require secure access, privacy safeguards, beneficial-ownership checks and audit. Anti-circumvention clauses should cover split gifts and benefits routed through relatives. Deliberate concealment may invite discipline only after notice, evidence, impartial inquiry, reasons and appeal. Aggregate reporting and periodic review should identify recurring sectors. The objective is trusted impartiality, not indiscriminate exposure of family privacy or an assumption that every declared interest is misconduct.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 4 - 15 marks

Question: Codes fail when they are treated as documents rather than institutions. Discuss the roles of ownership, advice, training, monitoring and review. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

A code without an owner becomes an orphan: employees cannot obtain interpretations, leaders avoid responsibility and obsolete clauses persist. A designated ethics office should maintain the code, issue plain guidance, provide confidential prospective advice, manage registers and recommend revision. It needs sufficient independence from line pressure while remaining accountable to a competent authority.

Training should use Indian administrative scenarios rather than ceremonial pledges. Officials must practise conflict recognition, stakeholder mapping, written-direction safeguards, recusal, information handling, reasoned discretion and safe escalation. Leaders should disclose their own interests and reward ethical problem-solving, not targets achieved by hidden shortcuts.

Monitoring should combine lagging indicators such as proven breaches with leading indicators: advice demand, late declarations, recusal quality, audit anomalies, near misses and anonymous climate surveys. Falling complaints are not success if reporting is unsafe. Annual aggregate reports should state trends, action and learning while protecting lawful confidentiality.

Periodic review should use cases, tribunal findings, technology and stakeholder experience, operate prospectively and preserve certainty. Institution-building durably turns aspiration into ethical competence and precise conduct rules into fair, adaptive practice.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 5 - 20 marks

Question: Examine India's ethics-and-conduct architecture for civil servants, Ministers and legislators. Suggest a coherent reform model without collapsing political, disciplinary and criminal accountability. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

India has multiple role-specific layers rather than one universal code. Civil servants are governed by enforceable conduct rules: the CCS framework, for example, covers general integrity and devotion, political activity, media and public criticism, official information, gifts, outside employment and property. Ministers operate under political responsibility and an existing conduct framework involving interests, official resources and accountability. Each House owns legislative ethics through its rules and committee processes; Rajya Sabha rules provide for a code, interests register, complaints and recommended sanctions.

The major gap is not absence of all conduct control. The Second ARC recommended comprehensive public-service values and ethics architecture, while the official 2024 GS-IV Q5(a) itself framed a Code of Ethics as not yet put in place. Such a code should guide constitutional fidelity, selflessness, impartiality, empathy, openness, leadership and honest advice, but must not be described as legally self-executing.

Reform should retain separate institutional routes. Service misconduct requires identified rules and disciplinary due process. A Minister may incur political consequence without a criminal conviction. Legislative breach follows House procedure. Corruption offences require statutory ingredients, investigation and court process. An ethics office can offer advice and training; interest registers, recusal protocols and annual reports improve prevention; independent investigation and appeal protect fairness.

Common minimum principles and interoperable disclosures can connect the system, but one body should not become adviser, prosecutor, judge and political sovereign. Coherence means shared values, precise role rules and distinct lawful accountability.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Question: A department discovers that senior officials split hospitality benefits among family members, use private messaging for official directions and punish junior officers who seek ethics advice. Propose a complete institutional response. Answer in about 250 words.

The facts indicate circumvention, record avoidance, conflict risk and retaliation. Immediate steps should preserve lawfully obtainable evidence, protect affected officers, stop further benefits and separate implicated officials from relevant decisions without presuming guilt. The competent authority should identify applicable gift, conflict, information, record and disciplinary provisions. Anonymous claims require corroboration; accused persons require notice, relevant material, impartial inquiry and an opportunity to respond.

A confidential advice function should be institutionally separated from investigation, with a clear non-retaliation rule and safe escalation. Training should use the discovered pattern as an anonymised scenario. Monitoring should track advice requests, retaliation allegations, split benefits, late disclosures and repeat vendor links. Reasoned sanctions should reflect intent, value, harm, seniority and obstruction, with appeal.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER Subject: Ethics | **GS Paper:** GS-IV | **Topic owner:** 16 This companion deepens institutional design, jurisprudential limits, comparative reasoning and enforcement trade-offs after the Basic owner has been completed. **FACT:** = source-grounded fact | **ANALYSIS:** = analysis/inference | **CURRENT:** = current official anchor.

```

      ETHICS INFRASTRUCTURE
      |
VALUES -----> RULES -----> PROCEDURES
  |             |             |
  v             v             v
ADVICE         RECORDS        FAIR INQUIRY
  |             |             |
  v             v             v
TRAINING -----> MONITORING -----> SANCTION / REMEDY
      |
      v
    REVIEW AND REVISION
  
```

- helps people recognise and resolve risk before breach;
- makes conduct observable and reviewable;
- protects lawful dissent and consultation;

- investigates allegations fairly;
- corrects harm and organisational weakness; and
- updates rules without retroactive punishment.

2. A spectrum rather than a watertight binary

The ethics/conduct distinction remains controlling, but real systems lie on a spectrum.

Instrument	Typical character	Advanced qualification
statement of values	highly aspirational	may influence appraisal or interpretation without itself defining misconduct
ethics code with examples	principle-led and educative	examples improve notice but do not automatically create penalties
conduct code	specific and procedural	may contain open-textured duties such as "integrity"
service rule	legally authorised employment norm	requires disciplinary procedure and review
House rule	institution-specific constitutional/parliamentary procedure	political and privilege dimensions differ from service law
criminal statute	offence, investigation and court sanction	highest stigma; requires statutory ingredients and criminal process

ANALYSIS: Do not confuse breadth with weakness. A broad integrity duty may be enforceable if competently incorporated, but overbroad use can violate notice and invite selective punishment. Likewise, a detailed rule may be legally valid yet ethically under-inclusive.

Minimum-compliance paradox

A detailed code can unintentionally teach:

"Everything outside the prohibited list is ethically acceptable."

The response is not unlimited discretion. It is a layered system:

1. specific conduct rules for notice;
2. general principles for purpose and circumvention;
3. accessible prospective advice;
4. reasoned, reviewable application; and
5. prospective clarification after new patterns emerge.

3. The Second ARC's civil-service proposal: precise reading

FACT: The Fourth Report states that public-service values towards which all public servants should aspire should be defined and made applicable to all tiers of Government and parastatal organisations.

FACT: It recommends that conflict of interest be comprehensively covered in both the Code of Ethics and the Code of Conduct for officers.

FACT: It also observes that organisations, especially those with a public interface, should prescribe codes appropriate to their operating risks rather than relying only on a service-wide document.

Advanced caveat

The ARC formulation combines:

- aspirational public-service values; and
- a recommendation that transgression should attract misconduct consequences.

ANALYSIS: Therefore, avoid the simplistic claim that the ARC wanted a purely voluntary poster. An aspirational Code of Ethics is not legally self-executing. Equally, do not say the ARC report itself enacted misconduct. A recommendation becomes enforceable only through competent legal implementation.

Current status formulation

Use:

India has enforceable conduct rules containing ethical duties, but the Second ARC-recommended comprehensive and coherent civil-service Code of Ethics/public-service-values framework remains unimplemented as a distinct national architecture.

Avoid:

- "India has no ethics in its service rules."
- "The ARC Code of Ethics is already law."
- "India has no Code of Conduct for public servants."

4. Values-to-rules translation: the regulatory design problem

Example: integrity

INTEGRITY

- |
- +--> no improper obligation
- +--> disclose material interest
- +--> do not misuse information
- +--> do not seek private benefit

|

v

RISK-SPECIFIC RULES

- |
- +--> gifts / hospitality
- +--> relatives / beneficial ownership
- +--> outside employment
- +--> future employment
- +--> property reporting

|

v

PROCEDURES

- |
- +--> declaration
- +--> independent assessment
- +--> recusal / restriction / divestment
- +--> record and audit

Six tests for a translated rule

1. **Authority:** who may issue and enforce it?
2. **Notice:** can the covered person understand the duty?
3. **Fit:** does the rule address the identified risk?
4. **Proportionality:** is the burden no greater than needed?
5. **Administrability:** can disclosures and approvals be processed?
6. **Reviewability:** are reasons and remedies available?

ANALYSIS: More disclosure is not always better. Excessive family-data collection may produce privacy harm, security risk and false positives. Use role-sensitive and risk-sensitive disclosure.

5. Political neutrality and responsive government

Political neutrality creates a three-sided duty:

Relationship	Duty
to elected government	faithful implementation of lawful policy
to Constitution and law	resistance to unlawful or discriminatory instruction
to future governments and citizens	preserve professional capacity, records and impartial administration

ANALYSIS: Neutrality can fail in opposite ways:

- **partisan capture:** manipulating transfers, data, enforcement or schemes for party advantage;
- **bureaucratic veto:** frustrating lawful policy because officials prefer another ideology.

Minister-civil servant boundary

FACT: The ARC's ministerial ethical framework says Ministers should uphold civil-service political impartiality and should not ask civil servants to act contrary to their duties.

ANALYSIS: A credible code should also protect:

- candid advice;
- documented disagreement;
- lawful implementation after decision;
- responsibility of the political executive for policy; and
- responsibility of the permanent executive for legality, evidence and administration.

The official 2019 GS-IV discussion of politicisation of bureaucracy is a useful cross-topic example, but full political-executive case analysis belongs with the relevant case-study owner.

6. Speech, media and information in the digital workplace

Four categories

Category	Default ethical treatment
authorised official communication	accurate, role-bound and recorded
private expression unrelated to duty	protected subject to applicable lawful limits
partisan use of office or confidential data	strongly restricted
protected reporting of wrongdoing	use authorised, secure and proportionate routes

Digital-era risks

- private messaging used to avoid records;
- screenshot leakage of citizen or bidder data;
- anonymous partisan amplification by serving officials;
- undisclosed sponsored commentary;
- cloud tools processing protected official material;
- deletion of material directions;
- deepfake or manipulated official statements.

ANALYSIS: The answer is not total surveillance of employees. Use:

- authorised systems for material business;
- clear retention categories;
- privacy-protective logging;
- lawful device and information policy;
- secure reporting channels;
- proportional investigation based on evidence; and
- written reasons for access to employee data.

7. Conflict of interest: beyond disclose-and-recuse

Management options

LOW / REMOTE RISK ----- HIGH / DIRECT RISK

record only -> disclosure -> access restriction -> recusal/reassignment
-> independent review -> divestment -> withdrawal from role

The choice depends on:

- value and concentration of interest;
- decision power;
- availability of substitutes;
- access to non-public information;
- duration of conflict;
- public appearance;
- impact on vulnerable persons; and
- risk of strategic manipulation.

Actual, potential, apparent and perceived

“Apparent conflict” should not become punishment for every suspicion. The standard is a **reasonable, informed observer**, not social-media hostility. Management can be necessary to protect trust even where actual bias is unproved; sanction still requires proof of the charged breach.

Regulatory capture and revolving doors

Post-employment restrictions should address:

- negotiating employment while regulating;
- switching sides in the same matter;
- using confidential information;
- privileged access to former subordinates; and
- compensation linked to official decisions.

ANALYSIS: Cooling-off periods should be role- and risk-sensitive. Excessive bans deter expertise and may violate livelihood interests without proportional benefit.

8. Gifts, hospitality and beneficial ownership

Substance-over-form analysis

```
FORMAL RECIPIENT
|
v
OFFICIAL? SPOUSE? CHILD? ASSOCIATE? FOUNDATION? INTERMEDIARY?
|
v
WHO FUNDED IT? WHO BENEFITED? WHAT DECISION WAS PENDING?
|
v
AGGREGATE CONNECTED BENEFITS
|
v
APPLY CURRENT RULE + CONFLICT TEST + FAIR INQUIRY
```

ANALYSIS: Anti-circumvention does not permit guilt by association. Investigators need evidence of connection, knowledge, benefit and applicable duty. Innocent ceremonial, family or widely available benefits require fair distinction.

Threshold fallacy

A monetary trigger may govern:

- reporting;
- prior permission;

- surrender;
- valuation; or
- outright prohibition.

It does not answer every ethical question. A below-trigger benefit from a regulated company during a live inspection may still create a conflict or violate another clause.

9. Legislatures: self-regulation and public legitimacy

FACT: Current official Rajya Sabha rules establish:

- a Committee on Ethics;
- oversight of moral and ethical conduct;
- preparation and amendment of a Code of Conduct;
- a Register of Members' Interests;
- written complaints by any person;
- committee inquiry; and
- recommended sanctions including censure, reprimand and specified suspension.

Institutional trade-off

House control respects legislative autonomy and privilege, but risks partisan protection or majoritarian punishment.

Possible safeguards include:

- published admissibility criteria;
- declaration of committee-member conflicts;
- fair notice and evidence access;
- reasoned reports;
- consistent sanction principles;
- public reporting subject to legitimate confidentiality; and
- independent technical or ethics advice.

ANALYSIS: An independent adviser should not displace the House's constitutional role. The design question is how to add professional, non-partisan capacity while preserving lawful institutional competence.

10. Ministers: political accountability and procedural fairness

Ministerial codes often operate differently from civil-service disciplinary rules.

Civil servant	Minister
service relationship and disciplinary rules	political office and collective responsibility
identified misconduct charge	political confidence and standards of office
formal inquiry and service penalty	explanation, censure, resignation or removal may arise politically
appeal/tribunal/court routes may apply	legislative and Prime Minister/Chief Minister accountability

ANALYSIS: Political action need not await criminal conviction. Yet accusations should not automatically produce punishment without fact checking. A model may combine:

- rapid preliminary fact assessment;
- publication of applicable standard;
- opportunity to respond;
- independent advice or investigation for disputed facts;
- reasoned political decision; and
- separate referral where criminal or service-law issues arise.

Coalition problem

FACT: The ARC recommended that the Prime Minister or Chief Minister remain duty-bound to ensure observance even where coalition Ministers belong to different parties.

ANALYSIS: Ethical standards cannot become optional coalition bargaining terms; equally, enforcement must not become a weapon applied only to junior allies.

11. Advice, investigation and adjudication

Why prospective advice matters

Many ethics problems are preventable if an official can safely ask:

- Must I declare this holding?
- May I attend this event?
- Should I recuse?
- Can I publish this article?
- May I accept this outside role?
- How should I handle an oral direction?

Role-conflict risk

If the same office:

1. receives confidential facts;
2. advises a course;
3. investigates departure;
4. prosecutes; and
5. decides guilt,

employees may stop asking and procedural fairness may suffer.

ANALYSIS: Separation need not mean five agencies. It can mean internal firewalls, recusal, limited use of advisory communications, independent decision-makers and published confidentiality rules.

12. Monitoring: gaming-resistant ethics metrics

Bad metrics

- number of pledges signed;
- attendance at one lecture;
- raw number of sanctions;
- falling complaints without accessibility data;
- 100% forms filed without quality review;
- no reported conflicts in a high-risk unit.

Better dashboard

Dimension	Indicator	Interpretation caution
advice	volume, response time, recurring themes	more requests may show trust, not more wrongdoing
disclosure	timeliness and completeness	quantity does not prove quality
recusal	reasons and reassignment quality	excessive recusal may disable administration
culture	speak-up and retaliation survey	perception requires triangulation
control	repeat audit anomalies	anomaly is not automatically misconduct
enforcement	time, consistency, appeals upheld	speed cannot replace fairness
learning	rules revised after repeated ambiguity	constant revision can reduce certainty

ANALYSIS: Publish aggregate findings, not raw personal data, unless lawful process and public interest justify disclosure.

13. Sanctions, due process and Article 311 context

For civil servants, constitutional and service-law protections make discipline an institutional process, not managerial anger.

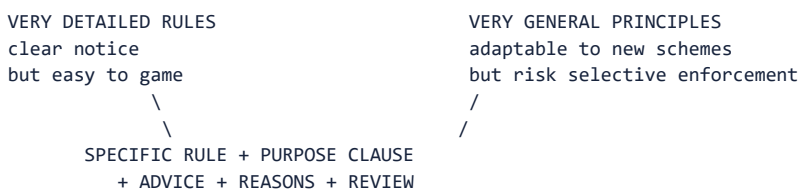
Fair-enforcement tests

1. **Legality:** identify the applicable rule and competent authority.
2. **Particularity:** state the act, time and alleged breach.
3. **Evidence:** preserve and disclose relevant material fairly.
4. **Impartiality:** remove investigator or decision-maker conflicts.
5. **Hearing:** allow meaningful response.
6. **Reason:** address defence and evidence.
7. **Proportionality:** distinguish error, negligence, recklessness and deliberate concealment.
8. **Consistency:** explain departure from comparable outcomes.
9. **Review:** preserve the applicable appeal or judicial route.
10. **Remedy:** correct citizen or institutional harm, not only punish the employee.

ANALYSIS: Article 311 should not be presented as immunity from discipline. It structures protection against arbitrary dismissal, removal or reduction in rank while permitting lawful disciplinary action.

14. Loopholes versus vagueness

There is a genuine design tension:



Safe anti-loophole method

- identify the specific applicable duty;
- explain the rule's public purpose;
- prove the connected transaction or benefit;
- address innocent explanations;
- avoid retroactive creation of misconduct;
- impose consequence only within valid authority;

- clarify the rule prospectively if ambiguity was genuine.

ANALYSIS: "Spirit of the code" is persuasive for advice and reform, but cannot substitute for legal notice where serious disciplinary sanction is imposed.

15. Ethical competence as organisational capability

Competence ladder

Level	Capability
1. Awareness	recognises obvious prohibited conduct
2. Rule literacy	finds the applicable rule and authority
3. Risk perception	sees conflict, appearance, bias and indirect benefit
4. Judgment	compares lawful alternatives and proportional controls
5. Courage	gives candid advice and escalates safely
6. Reflection	learns from near misses and revises practice
7. Leadership	creates conditions in which others can act ethically

The 2019 GS-IV institutional-measures question is best answered through three connected systems:

1. **anticipation:** risk registers, audits, near misses and stakeholder intelligence;
2. **competence:** scenario training, advice, mentoring and reasoned-decision practice;
3. **process:** disclosure, recusal, records, review, remedy and fair sanctions.

ANALYSIS: Punishment cannot create all seven levels. Excessive fear may suppress advice and hide early warning signals.

16. Comparative models: use without transplantation

UNCAC Article 8

FACT: UNCAC Article 8 calls on States Parties to promote integrity, honesty and responsibility and to apply codes or standards of conduct for correct, honourable and proper performance of public functions within their legal systems.

Use: international legitimacy for codes and interest-reporting architecture. Limit: it does not impose one universal text or erase domestic procedure.

UK-type ministerial responsibility

FACT: The ARC's comparative discussion highlights a model in which the Prime Minister is the ultimate political judge of ministerial conduct.

Use: speed, political responsibility and coherence. Limit: risk of partisan or discretionary enforcement without independent fact-finding.

Parliamentary standards commissioner model

FACT: The ARC discusses the UK Parliamentary Commissioner for Standards and Canadian Ethics Commissioner arrangements, including advice, registers, investigation and reporting.

Use: specialised capacity and continuity. Limit: Indian adoption must respect the constitutional competence of each House and avoid an unaccountable parallel sovereign.

Australia public-service model

FACT: The ARC notes Australian public-service values and a commissioner's role in evaluating how agencies incorporate and uphold them.

Use: connects values with organisational systems and annual service-wide assessment. Limit: transplant only after adapting federal structure, service law and administrative capacity.

17. Designing the missing civil-service Code of Ethics

Part I - identity and purpose

- constitutional fidelity;
- public office as entrusted responsibility;
- primacy of lawful public interest;
- service to every citizen, especially vulnerable groups;
- non-partisan professionalism.

Part II - values

- selflessness;
- integrity;
- objectivity and merit;
- impartiality;
- honesty;
- openness with lawful confidentiality;
- accountability;
- empathy and courtesy;
- courage in advice;
- stewardship;
- leadership by example.

Part III - decision principles

- identify authority and purpose;
- seek relevant evidence;
- declare interests;
- hear affected perspectives where appropriate;
- compare alternatives;
- minimise rights intrusion;
- give reasons;
- preserve records;
- accept review and correct error.

Part IV - operating support

- ethics office;
- confidential advice;
- induction and scenario training;
- role-specific guidance;
- leadership declarations;
- climate measurement;
- annual aggregate reporting;
- periodic review.

Part V - enforcement boundary

State expressly:

This Code guides aspiration, judgment, leadership, advice and interpretation. Disciplinary consequence arises only under applicable law or conduct rules through the competent procedure.

This sentence prevents the false implication that aspirational ethical language is automatically a legal offence.

18. Advanced UPSC traps

- WRONG: **India has no code for civil servants.**

FACT: CCS/AIS conduct rules exist; the gap concerns a distinct comprehensive ethics code.

- WRONG: **All clauses in a Code of Ethics are voluntary.**

FACT: Values can be validly incorporated into enforceable rules, but aspiration alone creates no penalty.

- WRONG: **Conflict proves corruption.**

FACT: Conflict is a risk condition; concealment, biased action or bribery requires evidence.

- WRONG: **Disclosure always solves conflict.**

FACT: Material conflict may require recusal, reassignment or divestment.

- WRONG: **Any benefit below a monetary threshold is ethical.**

FACT: Thresholds do not defeat conflict, anti-circumvention or other prohibitions.

- WRONG: **Asset return equals public online disclosure.**

FACT: Regimes differ in access, confidentiality and purpose.

- WRONG: **Neutrality requires silent obedience.**

FACT: It requires candid non-partisan advice and lawful implementation.

- WRONG: **Confidentiality requires concealment of wrongdoing.**

FACT: Use lawful protected channels; avoid indiscriminate leakage.

- WRONG: **Ethics Committee recommendation is final House punishment.**

FACT: Inquiry/recommendation and House action are distinct procedural stages.

- WRONG: **2025 Q5(a) is the missing-code question.**

FACT: 2024 Q5(a) is the direct gap question; 2025 Q5(a) is devotion to duty; 2025 Q6(a) is workplace code.

19. PYQ synthesis

2018 cluster

The four relevant demands form one sequence:

```
DISTINGUISH THE CODES
      v
DEFINE PUBLIC INTEREST
      v
CONTROL PRIVATE INTEREST
      v
LIMIT "NOT PROHIBITED" DISCRETION
```

An examiner expects precision plus application, not a list of virtues.

2019 cluster

The institutional-measures question requires:

- anticipation;
- competence; and
- integrity-supporting process.

Use an organisation-wide system rather than recommending only moral education or harsher punishment.

2024-2025 cluster

- FACT: **2024 Q5(a)**: design a suitable ethics model while acknowledging existing conduct.
 - FACT: **2025 Q5(a)**: show how devotion becomes responsible, non-blind public service.
 - FACT: **2025 Q6(a)**: combine value-based culture with compliance-based mechanisms.
-

20. Examiner-grade answer frameworks

“Distinguish”

Step	Content
1	define each code
2	compare purpose, content and enforcement
3	give one civil-service example
4	give one minister/legislator example
5	state complementarity and self-execution caveat

“Suggest a model”

VALUES

- > DECISION PRINCIPLES
- > RISK-SPECIFIC GUIDANCE
- > OWNER AND ADVICE
- > TRAINING AND LEADERSHIP
- > DISCLOSURE / RECUSAL / RECORDS
- > MONITORING AND REPORTING
- > FAIR ENFORCEMENT UNDER SEPARATE VALID RULES
- > REVIEW

“Critically examine”

Use:

1. benefit of codification;
2. implementation limits;
3. enforcement trade-off;
4. loophole/vagueness tension;
5. competence and culture;
6. qualified reform.

Advanced conclusion: Ethics codes should enlarge judgment without enlarging arbitrary punishment; conduct codes should discipline behaviour without shrinking public service into box-ticking.

21. Advanced consolidated register notes

Institutional architecture

- Codes operate inside advice, training, records, monitoring, enforcement, remedy and revision.
- Treat the ethics/conduct distinction as controlling but not watertight.
- Values may be enforceable only through competent incorporation and fair procedure.
- Separate political, House, service and criminal accountability.

Design

- Translate value -> role meaning -> risk -> rule -> procedure -> owner -> evidence -> consequence -> review.
- Combine specific clauses with a purpose-sensitive anti-circumvention principle.
- Do not punish serious misconduct by retroactively inventing the “spirit” of an ambiguous code.
- Use role-sensitive disclosure and privacy minimisation.

High-risk domains

- political activity and official resources;
- public statements and confidential information;
- gifts and hospitality;
- relatives and beneficial ownership;

- assets and property;
- outside and post-employment;
- private messaging and record avoidance;
- retaliation against advice or reporting.

Implementation

- named ethics owner;
- confidential prospective advice;
- scenario-based competence;
- leadership example;
- leading plus lagging indicators;
- aggregate annual reporting;
- periodic prospective revision.

Fair enforcement

- applicable rule;
- evidence;
- notice and material;
- impartial inquiry;
- reasoned finding;
- proportional sanction;
- appeal and victim/institutional remedy.

Factual cautions

- Comprehensive ARC-recommended civil-service Code of Ethics remains unimplemented as a distinct national framework.
- Existing CCS/AIS conduct duties must not be denied.
- Verify mutable thresholds and forms in current official text.
- Direct gap question is 2024 Q5(a).
- 2025 Q5(a) is devotion to duty; 2025 Q6(a) is the workplace-code question.
- Topic 22 retains the full case-study method.

22. Source ledger

Local official material

- books\ethics4.pdf - Second ARC, Fourth Report, *Ethics in Governance*.
- books\more_previous_papers\GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf - 2018 GS-IV.
- books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-IV.pdf - 2019 GS-IV.
- books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-22-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER IV-190922.pdf - 2022 GS-IV.
- books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-23-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV-180923.pdf - 2023 GS-IV.
- books\mains\05 UPSC 2024 Paper-IV_Final 1.pdf - 2024 GS-IV.
- books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf - 2025 GS-IV.

Live official sources verified 29 August 2026

1. Department of Personnel and Training, ****Central Civil Services (Conduct) Rules, 1964**
(Updated)**: <https://dopt.gov.in/acts/central-civil-services-conduct-rules-1964-updated-0>
2. Rajya Sabha, **Committee on Ethics rules:**
https://cms.rajyasabha.nic.in/UploadedFiles/CommitteeSection/CommitteeRules/1626363812501.54_CommitteOnEthics.pdf

ANALYSIS: Current hosting verifies the live official rule architecture. It does not prove that every ARC recommendation has been enacted or that every threshold in an older consolidated PDF remains unchanged.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

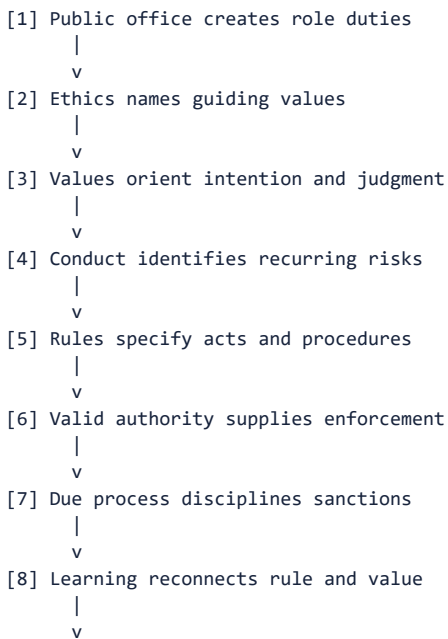
EMBEDDED TWELVE-PANEL ASCII REVISION ATLAS

The panels compress the learning route without replacing the complete teaching and solved practice above.

ASCII PANEL 1/12 - 1. Dual-code foundation

CENTRAL FOCUS

1. Dual-code foundation



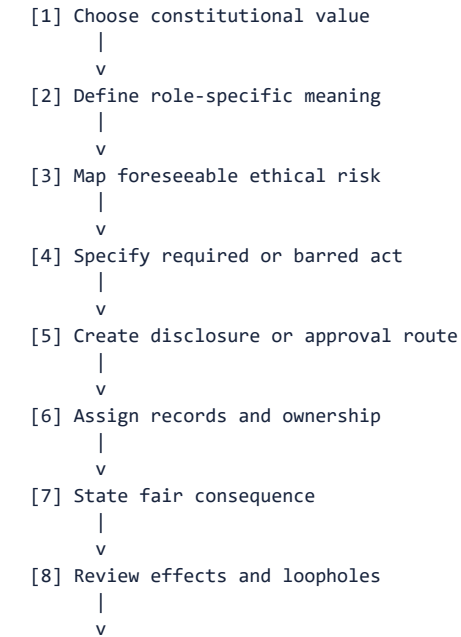
VERDICT -> Aspiration and enforceability are complementary, never automatic synonyms.

ANSWER USE -> Use to open every distinction or model-code answer.

ASCII PANEL 2/12 - 2. Values-to-rules translation

CENTRAL FOCUS

2. Values-to-rules translation



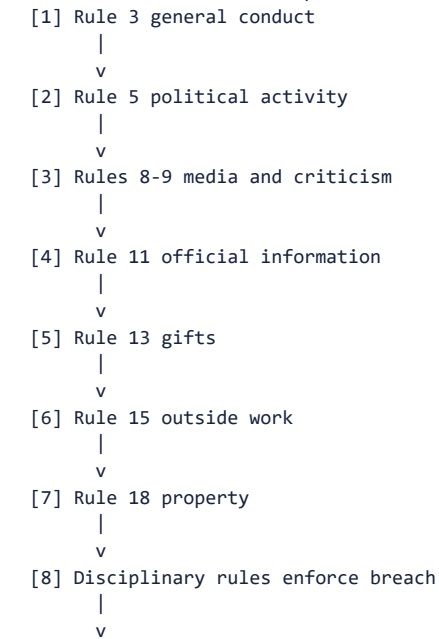
VERDICT -> A value becomes administratively usable through procedures without losing its purpose.

ANSWER USE -> Use for work-culture and institutional-design questions.

ASCII PANEL 3/12 - 3. Civil-service conduct map

CENTRAL FOCUS

3. Civil-service conduct map



VERDICT -> Cite the rule family safely; verify mutable thresholds in current notifications.

ANSWER USE -> Use for CCS conduct-rule applications.

ASCII PANEL 4/12 - 4. Neutral advice and implementation

CENTRAL FOCUS

4. Neutral advice and implementation

- [1] Check Constitution and law
 - |
 - v
- [2] Gather accurate evidence
 - |
 - v
- [3] Give candid options
 - |
 - v
- [4] Declare personal or party bias
 - |
 - v
- [5] Record material advice
 - |
 - v
- [6] Receive lawful policy decision
 - |
 - v
- [7] Implement without partisan favour
 - |
 - v
- [8] Escalate unlawful direction safely
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> Neutrality protects professional candour before decision and loyal legality after it.

ANSWER USE -> Use for political-neutrality and Minister-civil servant questions.

ASCII PANEL 5/12 - 5. Conflict management ladder

CENTRAL FOCUS

5. Conflict management ladder

- [1] Identify private interest
 - |
 - v
- [2] Classify actual potential apparent
 - |
 - v
- [3] Disclose before participation
 - |
 - v
- [4] Assess materiality independently
 - |
 - v
- [5] Restrict access if needed
 - |
 - v
- [6] Recuse reassign or divest
 - |
 - v
- [7] Record reasons and controls
 - |
 - v
- [8] Review outcome and recurrence
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> Disclosure starts management; it does not automatically cure a material conflict.

ANSWER USE -> Use for relatives, procurement and regulatory capture.

ASCII PANEL 6/12 - 6. Gift asset and outside-work controls

CENTRAL FOCUS

6. Gift asset and outside-work controls

[1] Gift may create obligation

|

v

[2] Hospitality may buy access

|

v

[3] Assets may reveal interest

|

v

[4] Outside work divides loyalty

|

v

[5] Future job may distort regulation

|

v

[6] Current rule fixes procedure

|

v

[7] Privacy limits over-disclosure

|

v

[8] Inquiry distinguishes risk from guilt

|

v

VERDICT -> Control influence and appearance without guessing thresholds or presuming corruption.

ANSWER USE -> Use for close-option traps and conflict examples.

ASCII PANEL 7/12 - 7. Ministers and legislators

CENTRAL FOCUS

7. Ministers and legislators

[1] Minister bears political responsibility

|

v

[2] Official and party resources separate

|

v

[3] Private interest yields to public duty

|

v

[4] Civil-service impartiality protected

|

v

[5] Member declares relevant interests

|

v

[6] Ethics Committee examines complaint

|

v

[7] Committee recommends sanction

|

v

[8] House acts through its procedure

|

v

VERDICT -> Political and House accountability can arise without collapsing into criminal conviction.

ANSWER USE -> Use for comparative public-functionary answers.

ASCII PANEL 8/12 - 8. Ethics-office ownership

CENTRAL FOCUS

8. Ethics-office ownership

- [1] Maintain authoritative code
 - |
 - v
- [2] Issue plain guidance
 - |
 - v
- [3] Give confidential advice
 - |
 - v
- [4] Train with scenarios
 - |
 - v
- [5] Manage registers
 - |
 - v
- [6] Receive or route complaints
 - |
 - v
- [7] Report aggregate trends
 - |
 - v
- [8] Propose periodic revision
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> A named owner turns a document into an operating ethics institution.

ANSWER USE -> Use for Second ARC and 2025 Q6(a).

ASCII PANEL 9/12 - 9. Fair enforcement route

CENTRAL FOCUS

9. Fair enforcement route

- [1] Identify valid applicable rule
 - |
 - v
- [2] Preserve relevant evidence
 - |
 - v
- [3] Give notice of allegation
 - |
 - v
- [4] Disclose material fairly
 - |
 - v
- [5] Use impartial inquiry
 - |
 - v
- [6] Reach reasoned finding
 - |
 - v
- [7] Match sanction to gravity
 - |
 - v
- [8] Provide review or appeal
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> Credible discipline requires both consequence and procedural justice.

ANSWER USE -> Use for sanction, Article 311 and workplace-enforcement analysis.

ASCII PANEL 10/12 - 10. Loophole and circumvention test

CENTRAL FOCUS

10. Loophole and circumvention test

- [1] Look beyond formal recipient
|
v
- [2] Aggregate connected benefits
|
v
- [3] Check relatives and intermediaries
|
v
- [4] Trace beneficial ownership
|
v
- [5] Test substance against purpose
|
v
- [6] Protect innocent explanation
|
v
- [7] Close ambiguity prospectively
|
v
- [8] Train from the near miss
|
v

VERDICT -> Literal compliance cannot legitimise a scheme designed to defeat the rule.

ANSWER USE -> Use for split gifts, shell interests and messaging avoidance.

ASCII PANEL 11/12 - 11. Ethical-competence cycle

CENTRAL FOCUS

11. Ethical-competence cycle

- [1] Notice the ethical signal
|
v
- [2] Find governing norm
|
v
- [3] Map stakeholders and bias
|
v
- [4] Generate lawful alternatives
|
v
- [5] Seek advice early
|
v
- [6] Choose and record reasons
|
v
- [7] Escalate or remedy safely
|
v
- [8] Reflect and improve practice
|
v

VERDICT -> Competence connects character, rule knowledge and practical judgment.

ANSWER USE -> Use for the 2019 institutional-measures PYQ.

ASCII PANEL 12/12 - 12. Complete examiner answer spine

CENTRAL FOCUS

12. Complete examiner answer spine

- [1] Define both codes precisely
 - |
 - v
- [2] State India's existing conduct layer
 - |
 - v
- [3] Preserve unimplemented-ethics caveat
 - |
 - v
- [4] Name role-specific risks
 - |
 - v
- [5] Translate values into procedures
 - |
 - v
- [6] Assign ownership and monitoring
 - |
 - v
- [7] Add fair enforcement and review
 - |
 - v
- [8] Conclude prevention plus accountability
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> The best answer joins aspiration, operational design and lawful consequence.

ANSWER USE -> Use for 2024 Q5(a), 2025 Q6(a) and original Mains practice.

ONE-PAGE CONCEPT GRID

Concept / thinker	Exam-ready formulation
Ethics codes guide aspiration; conduct codes specify behaviour	A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable.
An aspirational code is not legally self-executing	Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process.
Public servants face stricter role obligations	The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity.
Values require a translation chain	A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision.
Rule design must be clear without becoming mechanical	Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ.
Rule 3 supplies a general civil-service conduct floor	The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest.
Political neutrality differs from political indifference	Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice.
Written-direction safeguards protect responsibility	Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders.
Official information is governed by lawful purpose	Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable.
Public statements require role clarity	Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality.
Conflict of interest is a situation, not necessarily corruption	A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict.
Disclosure alone may not cure a material conflict	Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility.

CORE REVISION SPINE

- **Gifts and hospitality create obligation and appearance risks:** Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed.
- **Asset declarations are a risk-control instrument:** Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure.
- **Outside employment and post-employment create divided loyalty:** Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth.
- **Ministers combine ethical and political accountability:** A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved.
- **Legislative ethics uses House-owned procedures:** Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step.
- **Institutional ownership prevents an orphan code:** A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers.
- **Training must build ethical competence:** Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses.
- **Monitoring should combine leading and lagging indicators:** Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts.
- **Sanctions require legality, proof and proportionality:** Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition.
- **Advice and enforcement must be separated where fairness requires:** Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter.
- **Loophole compliance can violate the code's purpose:** Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps.
- **A mature ethics system learns and revises:** Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules.

SOURCE AND ATTRIBUTION DISCIPLINE

The corrected Topic 16 Basic and Advanced owners control the conceptual spine. A Code of Ethics is primarily aspirational and principle-based; a Code of Conduct specifies role behaviour, procedures and consequences. Do not say that an aspirational ethics code is legally self-executing. A value can become enforceable only when incorporated by competent law, service rule, House procedure, contract or other valid instrument and applied through due process. India does have enforceable conduct frameworks for civil servants and conduct or ethics arrangements for Ministers and legislators; the gap is not an absence of all codes. The Second ARC recommended public-service values applicable across governments and comprehensive treatment of conflicts in both ethics and conduct codes, but the recommended comprehensive civil-service Code of Ethics remains unimplemented as a distinct national framework. The official direct code-gap PYQ is 2024 GS-IV Q5(a). In the local official 2025 paper, Q5(a) concerns devotion to duty and is included only as an internalisation route; the direct organisational code question is 2025 Q6(a). CCS Rule

numbers are cited at a stable subject level: Rule 3 general conduct, Rule 5 politics, Rules 8-9 media and criticism, Rule 11 official information, Rule 13 gifts, Rule 15 private trade or employment and Rule 18 property. Exact monetary thresholds, forms, covered groups and amendment dates are mutable and must be verified in the current consolidated text or notification. Confidentiality does not license concealment of illegality, and whistleblowing does not authorise indiscriminate public disclosure. Conflict of interest is a risk condition requiring management, not automatic proof of corruption. Asset declarations are evidence inputs, not conclusive proof. Ethics Committee recommendations must not be described as identical to final House action. Ministerial political responsibility, service discipline, House privilege and criminal liability remain distinct accountability routes. Topic 16 teaches design and short applications; the full case-study method remains owned by Topic 22. Official PYQ PDFs control question text, while routing ledgers only allocate ownership.

ANSWER SPINE

1. Define the precise ethical concept or teaching.
2. State a qualified thesis rather than a moral slogan.
3. Explain the causal or decision-making mechanism.
4. Add one specific Indian administrative illustration.
5. Test the strongest limitation or attribution caveat.
6. End with a practical, institution-aware verdict.

SESSION 1 - WHY TWO CODES ARE NEEDED

- **FACT: Public-office premise:** entrusted authority, money, information and coercive power create role duties stricter than ordinary private choice.
- **FACT: Code of Ethics:** broad values and decision principles directed to aspiration, motive, judgment and institutional character.
- **FACT: Code of Conduct:** specific expected or prohibited behaviour, procedure, authority and consequence directed to controllable acts.
- **ANALYSIS: Core qualification:** an aspirational ethics code is not legally self-executing. Enforcement needs valid incorporation and due process.
- **Recall line:** Ethics gives the compass; conduct marks the lane; procedure checks the journey.

SESSION 2 - THE CONTROLLING DISTINCTION

- **Ethics question:** What should a worthy public servant or institution aspire to be and why?
- **Conduct question:** Who must do or avoid what, in which circumstances, through which route, with what consequence?
- **Overlap:** values may be incorporated into enforceable rules; rules still require purpose-sensitive interpretation.
- **UPSC trap:** do not write 'ethics has no sanctions' as an absolute. Say broad aspiration alone creates none; valid incorporation can make a standard enforceable.
- **India caveat:** existing conduct frameworks do not equal implementation of the ARC-recommended comprehensive civil-service Code of Ethics.

SESSION 3 - VALUES-TO-RULES TRANSLATION

- **Chain:** constitutional value -> role meaning -> ethical risk -> specific rule -> procedure -> record -> owner -> consequence -> review.
- **Integrity -> controls:** interest declaration, refusal of improper benefit, written reasons and independent review.
- **Impartiality -> controls:** objective criteria, equal information, recusal, reassignment and audit.
- **Openness -> controls:** reasoned decisions and lawful disclosure, bounded by privacy, security and deliberative needs.
- **Service -> controls:** accessibility, courtesy, time standards, grievance remedy and attention to weaker sections.
- **Design tests:** clarity, scope, exceptions, competent authority, proportionality, consistency and resistance to circumvention.

SESSION 4 - CIVIL-SERVICE CONDUCT RULES

- **FACT: CCS Rule 3:** integrity, devotion to duty, becoming conduct, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest.
- **FACT: Rule families:** Rule 5 political activity; Rules 8-9 media and criticism; Rule 11 official information; Rule 13 gifts; Rule 15 outside work; Rule 18 property.
- **Neutrality:** candid non-partisan advice before decision plus faithful implementation of lawful policy after decision.
- **Directions:** seek written confirmation of material oral directions under the applicable Rule 3 supervisory safeguards; do not treat this as a licence to obstruct emergencies.
- **Information:** authorised use and lawful channels; neither leakage nor blanket secrecy.
- **Mutable-data warning:** verify current thresholds, forms, group coverage and amendments before quoting them.

SESSION 5 - CONFLICT, GIFTS, ASSETS AND OUTSIDE INTERESTS

- **Conflict:** private interest could improperly influence or reasonably appear to influence duty; identify actual, potential and apparent forms.
- **Management ladder:** identify -> disclose -> assess materiality -> restrict access -> recuse/reassign/divest as needed -> record -> review.
- **Disclosure is not cure:** a spouse-controlled bidder normally requires withdrawal from the decision, not merely a declaration.
- **Gifts/hospitality:** test obligation, access, reciprocity and appearance; aggregate connected benefits and examine relatives or intermediaries.
- **Assets:** risk-screening and accountability evidence subject to regime-specific privacy and procedure; not automatic proof of corruption.
- **Outside/post-employment:** control divided loyalty, confidential information and capture through permission, recusal and proportionate cooling-off.

SESSION 6 - MINISTERS AND LEGISLATORS

- **Ministers:** public interest, collective responsibility, truthful accountability to the legislature, conflict control, separation of government and party resources, protection of civil-service impartiality.
- **Legislators:** interest declaration, non-acceptance of benefits for parliamentary acts, dignity of the House and complaint-based ethics review.
- **FACT: Rajya Sabha rules:** Committee oversight, Code preparation and revision, Register of Members' Interests, complaints and recommended sanctions.
- **Institutional caution:** committee recommendation is not the same procedural step as final House action.
- **Accountability distinction:** political resignation, House discipline, service penalty and criminal conviction have different triggers and forums.

SESSION 7 - OWNERSHIP, ADVICE, TRAINING, MONITORING AND REVIEW

- **Owner:** maintains text, guidance, registers, advice, training, complaints routing, annual trends and revision proposals.
- **Advice:** confidential, prospective and accessible; separate from investigation where role conflict would undermine fairness.
- **Training:** scenario practice in conflict recognition, bias, written directions, information, recusal, reasons and escalation.
- **Monitoring:** combine complaints and sanctions with advice demand, late disclosure, recusal quality, audit anomalies, near misses and climate surveys.
- **Review:** use cases, tribunal findings, technology and stakeholders; revise prospectively with transition guidance.

SESSION 8 - SANCTIONS AND DUE PROCESS

- **Sequence:** valid rule -> preserved evidence -> notice -> relevant disclosure -> impartial inquiry -> reasoned finding -> proportionate sanction -> review/appeal.

- **Proportionality factors:** intent, benefit, harm, seniority, repetition, concealment, cooperation and consistency with comparable cases.
- **No presumption:** conflict or asset anomaly is not itself proved corruption; investigation must establish the charged breach.
- **No ritual leniency:** seniority and reputation cannot erase evidence or victim remedy.
- **Purpose:** enforcement protects trust and learning; raw punishment counts are not an ethics-performance metric.

SESSION 9 - LOOPHOLES AND ETHICAL COMPETENCE

- **Loopholes:** split gifts, family routing, shell ownership, private messaging, strategic ignorance, selective disclosure and literal compliance defeating purpose.
- **Anti-circumvention:** aggregate benefits, examine connected persons and beneficial ownership, preserve substance-over-form review and protect innocent explanations.
- **Ethical competence:** recognise signal, locate norm, map stakeholders and bias, generate lawful alternatives, seek advice, record reasons, escalate and learn.
- **Culture test:** employees should be safer for seeking advice; retaliation converts a code into concealment machinery.
- **2019 PYQ line:** anticipate threats + strengthen competence + redesign administrative processes.

SESSION 10 - PYQ AND ANSWER ARCHITECTURE

- **FACT: 2018:** distinction between codes; public interest; conflict of interest; limits of 'not prohibited' reasoning.
- **FACT: 2019:** institutional measures for threats, competence and integrity-promoting processes.
- **FACT: 2022:** purposive interpretation of common rules.
- **FACT: 2023:** conscience compared with laws, rules and regulations.
- **FACT: 2024 Q5(a):** direct Code-of-Ethics model and unimplemented-gap premise.
- **FACT: 2025 Q5(a):** devotion-to-duty route only; **2025 Q6(a):** direct workplace ethics-and-compliance question.
- **10-mark spine:** define -> distinguish -> two Indian examples -> qualification -> concise synthesis.
- **15-mark spine:** diagnose risks -> values-to-rules table -> implementation ownership -> due-process qualification.
- **20-mark spine:** role-wise architecture -> gaps -> integrated reform -> separate accountability routes -> balanced conclusion.
- **Final thesis:** India needs neither ethics without enforceability nor discipline without ethical competence; it needs shared values, precise role rules, usable advice, credible monitoring and fair consequence.